1999 because he'd been suspended for that as well. He's intense about his soccer, passionate about playing for United. Real at Old Trafford was another huge game. I've been playing soccer with Scholesy half my life, for United and for England. Think about the two of us, as people, and you'd probably say we've not got much in common. Paul's quiet. He's so private that the other lads are always giving him grief about it. The rumor is that he turns off his cell phone straight after training and doesn't turn it on again until he's five minutes from Carrington the next morning. And as for his home number, he's given it out to so few people down the years he's probably forgotten what it is himself.

Scholesy's always just kept his head down and got on with soccer. I don't know a Premiership player, apart from him, who hasn't got an agent. Actually there's quite a few things that set Scholesy apart. He's an amazing one-touch player, who scores all the goals from midfield any manager could ask for. Plus he's got a temper as scary as Keano's or the boss's once he gets going. Like I say, we played through some history together at United and I hope we'll play through some more with England over the next three or four years. I've always got on well with Paul but you're never going to have a dressing room full of people who want to go out to dinner with each other every night.

After the final whistle at the Bernabeu, we went down to say thanks to the United fans. The club competes in the Champions League season after season. I wonder sometimes how people find the time or the money. They do, though. There are Manchester United fans in Europe in their thousands wherever and whenever the team play. I was hobbling a bit by then and when I got back to the dressing room, I was on the treatment table for a long while. The hamstring was really sore. It kept me out of the team for the Premiership match against Newcastle the following Saturday. I was frustrated about it but there was nothing I could do. It meant I missed the game that put the stamp on our season. I think winning 6–2 at St James' Park was the result that pushed us on to winning the League. Ole Gunnar Solskjaer came in and did really well in place of me.

I was back training with everybody else first thing on Monday morning. We were away to Arsenal on the Wednesday night: as far as the Premiership goes, the biggest match of the season. We'd got ourselves into a position where, as long as we didn't lose to Arsenal, it would be very difficult for them to catch us over the last four or five games. The way we were feeling, we thought we'd win every game until the end of the season anyway. I was pretty confident I'd play. I knew I was fit enough. No manager likes to change a winning team and 6–2 away was definitely a winning team. Even so, the boss